

Mapping Urban and Suburban Space in the Houston MSA

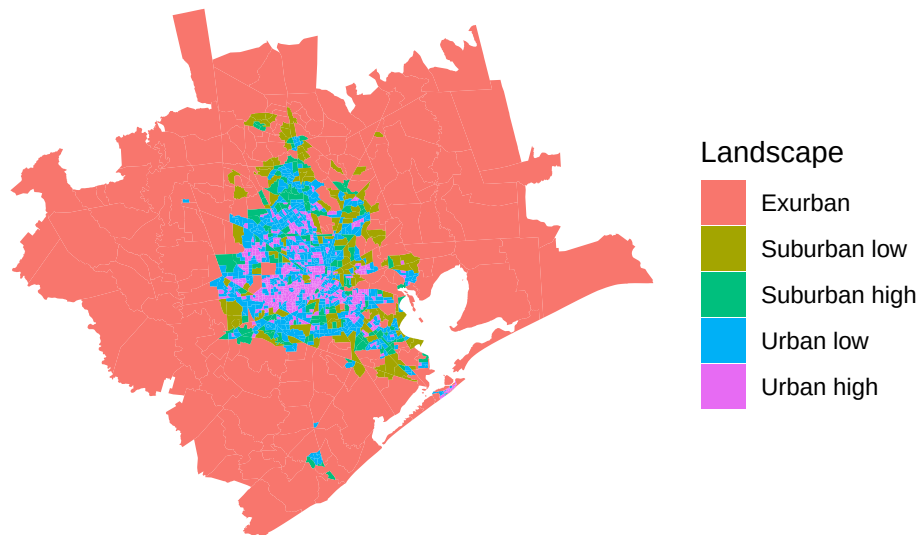
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Introduction

Houston was selected for this project because it is one of the largest and fastest-growing metropolitan areas in the United States and represents a highly decentralized form of urban development. Unlike older monocentric cities that are organized around a single dense downtown core, Houston exhibits extensive suburban expansion and multiple activity centers connected through highways and automobile-oriented infrastructure. This makes Houston an appropriate case for examining the spatial distribution of urban, suburban, and exurban landscapes through Census tract population density classifications.

The landscape map demonstrates that the highest-density urban tracts are concentrated near central Houston and surrounding inner-city neighborhoods. Urban and suburban tracts extend outward along major transportation corridors, while exurban landscapes dominate the outer metropolitan fringe. The overall pattern reflects Houston's large spatial footprint, continued suburban expansion, and relatively low-density metropolitan growth compared to older northeastern cities.

Population-density landscapes in the Houston MSA
2020 Census tracts classified using Hanberry-style density thresholds



Median household income by Census tract
Houston MSA, 2016–2020 ACS 5-year estimates

